

How the War Changed Universities in Syria

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Summary

The Syrian war did not simply interrupt university life; it **changed the structure, governance, staffing, student body, and perceived value of universities**. The strongest evidence suggests six major shifts:

1. **Universities became physically unsafe and institutionally fragmented.**
2. **Governance became more securitized and politicized.**
3. **Faculty losses and displacement weakened teaching and research quality.**
4. **Student access changed: in some ways broader on paper, but far more unequal and fragile in practice.**
5. **Student demographics and study patterns shifted, including a higher share of women and more online learning.**
6. **Degrees and career pathways became less portable, especially across conflict lines and borders.**

The result is a system that still exists, but operates under long-term damage from violence, displacement, and state-security intrusion.

What changed

1) Campuses stopped being reliably civilian learning spaces

A central change was the loss of the university as a stable, protected place for learning. The 2019 Cambridge/CARA report on Syrian higher education describes the post-2011 system as "fragmented and broken," citing:

- destruction of higher-education facilities and infrastructure
- militarization of campuses
- forced displacement of students and faculty
- lack of qualified teaching staff
- failed or non-existent accountability structures
- disruption of education and academic mobility

This was not only an early-war phenomenon. Scholars at Risk documented a **2024** artillery strike on student housing at the University of Aleppo, killing two students and injuring eleven. That suggests universities and dormitories have remained exposed to direct conflict violence well into the later phase of the war.

Interpretation: the war changed universities from relatively durable public institutions into vulnerable conflict-zone infrastructure.

2) University governance became more tied to security control

Before 2011, Syrian universities were already politically constrained. The war appears to have intensified that trend. The Cambridge/CARA report describes a stronger role for the **security apparatus** in university governance after 2011, including militarized governance, intimidation, and politicized management. Students in the report described security forces as a persistent presence on campus.

Scholars at Risk's 2013 account argues that universities functioned as extensions of the security state, with pro-regime student organizations, monitoring, searches, interrogations, and arrests on campus. Its framing is advocacy-oriented, so it should be read cautiously, but it aligns with the broader post-2011 picture in the Cambridge/CARA study.

Interpretation: the war did not just damage buildings; it changed the internal logic of universities, making security and political loyalty more central to how campuses operated.

3) Faculty flight and loss of expertise damaged teaching quality

One of the clearest changes is the loss of academic staff.

The Cambridge/CARA report records respondents saying teaching staff were **"currently 50% under the required number"** and that **"approximately 60% of teaching assistants and professors have left the university"** in at least one reported case. The same report repeatedly links declining quality to:

- exile and displacement of academics
- deaths, disappearances, and conscription
- reliance on less experienced replacement staff
- lecturers teaching outside their specialization
- outdated curricula and textbooks
- weak practical training and research opportunities

A 2017 *University World News* report, citing Ben Webster of the Jamiya Project, said **more than 2,000 Syrian academics had left the country**. I treat that figure as a secondary estimate rather than a definitive count, but it is directionally consistent with the broader evidence of brain drain.

Interpretation: the war changed universities from institutions anchored by accumulated expertise into systems struggling to replace lost human capital.

4) Access became easier in some formal respects, but harsher in real life

This is one of the more counterintuitive findings.

The Cambridge/CARA report says **post-2011 access increased in a narrow administrative sense** because admission thresholds were lowered as application numbers and competition fell. It states that for many institutions, **"Almost anyone who passed the Secondary School General Examination (Baccalaureate) could now pursue HE."**

But that did **not** mean universities became more accessible in a meaningful social sense. The same body of evidence shows access was constrained by:

- insecurity and shelling
- checkpoints and transport barriers
- poverty and displacement
- inability to obtain documents
- higher effective costs of attendance
- fear of arrest or conscription
- regional inequalities

So the war changed access in two opposite ways at once:

- **easier formal entry**, because demand collapsed and thresholds fell
- **harder real participation**, because conflict conditions made enrollment, attendance, and completion more precarious

Interpretation: the war widened the gap between being admitted to university and actually being able to study successfully.

5) The student body changed, including gender balance and study mode

The war also changed **who** attended university and **how** they studied.

The Cambridge/CARA report says that after 2011, **women became about 60% of the overall student body**, reversing the earlier gender balance. The report links this partly to the migration and militarization affecting men. At the same time, it notes that women still faced amplified security and economic barriers, especially low-income women with weak political connections.

The same report also describes a shift toward online learning. One respondent said **more than 200,000 students were enrolled in online education in the 2013-2014 academic year**. I would not treat that as a nationally verified administrative figure, but it is good evidence that conflict accelerated demand for remote and alternative study modes.

The official Syrian higher-education portal also highlights **open education** and the **Syrian Virtual University**, which fits the broader pattern of more flexible or distance-oriented provision.

****Interpretation:**** the war altered both student composition and delivery mode, pushing universities toward more feminized enrollment patterns and greater use of distance learning.

6) Degrees became less portable and labor-market links weakened

The war changed not just study conditions but what university credentials could do for graduates.

The Cambridge/CARA report says graduates in some areas faced restricted opportunities because of the ****lack of recognition of university qualifications from non-regime-controlled areas****. It also describes weak alignment between programs and labor-market demand, poor career support, and high unemployment.

That matters because universities normally provide not only education but also a route into professional life. In wartime Syria, that route became more uncertain.

****Interpretation:**** the war reduced the signaling power and mobility value of some Syrian university degrees, especially where institutions were politically or territorially isolated.

What remained in place

Despite all this, the higher-education system did not disappear.

Official Syrian sources still describe a centralized system under the Ministry of Higher Education and Scientific Research, including:

- public universities
- private universities
- intermediate institutes
- open education
- Syrian Virtual University

World Bank/UIS-linked data also suggest that Syria still had a large tertiary system in the mid-war period, with the latest non-null values I retrieved showing:

- ****gross tertiary enrollment ratio:**** 43.76% in 2016
- ****total tertiary enrollment:**** 697,415 in 2016
- ****female tertiary GER:**** 47.38% in 2016
- ****male tertiary GER:**** 40.44% in 2016

But the key limitation is that the internationally comparable statistical record becomes thin after that. So the system's recent scale is much harder to state precisely.

Bottom line

The war changed Syrian universities in at least four deep ways:

- from **campuses** into partly militarized and insecure spaces
- from **academic institutions** into more heavily securitized and politicized ones
- from **expert-led systems** into depleted systems coping with staff loss
- from **relatively legible educational pathways** into fragile, unequal, and sometimes non-portable routes

So the main story is not simply that universities were damaged. It is that the war **reconfigured** what a university is for, who can use it, who teaches in it, and what its degrees are worth**.**

Uncertainty and limits

- The best system-wide analytical report I found is from **2019**, drawing heavily on research conducted in **2017-2018**.
- Recent national higher-education statistics for Syria are sparse and patchy.
- Some evidence, especially on repression and arrests, comes from advocacy organizations and participant testimony; it is useful but should not be treated as perfectly comprehensive.
- Conditions likely vary significantly across Syrian regions and institutions.

Sources

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